Bassano and Moroni Are Given To Detroit Institute of Arts

By WALTER HEIL

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DETROIT.—It is a question whether the title "Venetian Paintings" is quite warranted, as neither of the two masters who painted the pictures recently given to the Detroit Museum was born or lived in the City of the Lagoons. Both, however, were not only—politically speaking—subjects of the Venetian Republic, but also in their art so overwhelmingly influenced by the glorious models set by the capital, then at the zenith of its cultural and artistic growth, that the denomination "Venetian" seems more appropriate than the rather vague one, "North Italian."

Compared as artistic personalities, the two masters, Giacomo Bassano and Giovanni Battista Moroni, though almost exact contemporaries, and with the currents of their art directed toward the same pole, are as different from each other as are in their outward appearance the two paintings, one being a hasty sketch for a large figure picture, the other a finished and carefully executed portrait.

In the case of the little sketch representing "The Birth of Love," presented to the Museum by Mr. A. E. Silbermann of Vienna and New York, the attribution to Giacomo Bassano must be taken with "a grain of salt," although no other author's name seems to be possible for it. Giacomo da Ponte, called Bassano, born in Bassano near Venice between 1510 and 1515, was the fortunate father of four sons who, likewise painters, in the later period of their father's career (to which our picture undoubtedly belongs) worked under his guidance in closest collaboration. There are instances recorded where one of the five made the first design of a composition, the second a sketch in oil, the third executed the work, the fourth made corrections and modifications, while the fifth eventually made copies or replicas. Even the names on signed works give no definite proof of their respective authorship, since not only were paintings obviously done in the workshop given the signature of the father and head master, but also many of those for which one of the sons had received the commission were executed with the father's help, as for instance in the case of Francesco Bassano who called his father to Venice to assist him in his work in the palace of the doges. Thus, so far as unsigned works are concerned, which do not belong either to the early period of Giacomo or to a time considerably after his death in 1592, when some of the sons had established themselves as independent artists with more pronounced characteristics of their own, it is hardly possible to give any more precise attribution than "workshop of Giacomo Bassano."

There is, however, no doubt that Giacomo was the most important artist of the family and really responsible for the "Bassano style"; so that, after all, the attribution given to our little canvas is, from this less literal viewpoint, quite justified. As to Giacomo Bassano's art, he was at first the pupil of his father Francesco, an able though not very important painter in the style of Montagna. He then went to Venice, where he was greatly influenced by Titian and later by Tintoretto. Characteristic of him is his predilection for many-figured scenes of domestic and country life. He is in fact one of the first genre painters known in the history of art. Even in his altarpieces and other sacred subjects these genre-like features, in the form of comparatively large figures of men and animals not connected with the story to be pictured, often dominate the canvas to such an extent that the real scene, enacted by tiny figures in the background, becomes scarcely distinguishable. His special merits are his exquisite and luminous color, his clever mastery of the problems of "picturesque" lighting, and his bold and spirited brushwork. Our little canvas, in spite of its character as a sketch done without any pretentions, in hasty and nervous strokes, fully reveals all of these qualities. One word more might be said about the subject. It is a question whether these four women grouped under a tent, busying themselves with a baby whom one of them holds on her lap, may not represent the daughter of Pharoah and her companions who have found the little Moses. The willow basket at the left would confirm this hypothesis. It is, in fact, only the little cupid flying at the right and strewing flowers which caused us—tentatively—to label the painting. *The Birth of Love.* Further research might lead to the discovery of the executed piece, thus enabling us to establish the meaning of the scene more definitely.

Giovanni Battista Moroni, who painted the portrait which has come to the Museum recently as the generous gift of Mr. Howard Young, was, as we have said, a contemporary of Giacomo Bassano. He was born about 1520 in a village near Bergamo and died in 1578 in Brescia after he had spent practically all of his life in this city. He was a pupil of Moretto, the great Renaissance painter of Brescia, and as such formed under the indirect influence of Giorgione and the other leading Venetians. But somehow he is less "Venetian" than nearly all the other painters of the "terra firma." His comparatively sharp and precise drawing as well as his cool and subdued colors, clearly distinguish Moroni from all the Titianesque painters. He is—one is almost inclined to say—only a portrait painter, as his altarpieces are rare and compared with his portraits of far inferior quality, unless, as in some instances, they are partly redeemed by the portrait-like treatment of some of the heads. Invention was not the strong point of this master, who seems helpless once the model fails him. His gift of keen observation, on the other hand, and his masterly draughtsmanship, enabled him to produce excellent likenesses. His portraits, appealing in their unpretentious simplicity of pose, are utterly convincing as individual likenesses, though never raised into types or ennobled by the spirit of genius, like those of Titian. There is something of a photographic truthfulness to life about them, which fact at once explains their merit as well as their shortcomings. Our portrait, of a sympathetic but not very interesting looking young man, is a perfect example of Moroni's art, which somehow reminds us of the cool and straightforward "bourgeois" portraiture of some of the Dutch masters of the XVIIth century.

BROOKLYN MUSEUM HOLDS GROUP SHOW

On June 1st the Brooklyn Museum opened a group exhibition of paintings, sculpture and drawings by American and foreign artists, which will remain on view there until October 1st.

The international character of the showing is indicated by the list of exhibiting artists which follows: Harriet Blackstone, United States; Kenneth Frazier, United States; Arthur C. Goodwin, United States; Hans von Hayek, Germany; Berta de Hellebranth, Hungary; Elena de Hellebranth, Hungary; Fritz Herpfer, Germany; Malvina Hoffman, United States; Frank Horowitz, Russia; Koowhoo Ishii, Japan; C. A. Korthaus, Germany; Bessie Lasky, United States; Jean-Julien Lemordant, France; Ernst Liebermann, Germany; Edward Michael McKey, United States; Fausta Vittoria Mengarini, Italy; Ugo Mochi, Italy; Hans Neumann, Germany; Israel Paldi, Palestine; Roland Rolando, Germany; Rubin, Palestine; Rudolf Scheffler, Germany; Kwei Teng, China; Lajos Tihanyi, Hungary; Isabel Whitney, United States; Angel Zarraga, Mexico.

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